

Viscum album (Loranthaceae) European Mistletoe

Description Parasitic evergreen shrub that forms bunches up to 10 ft (3 m) across on host trees. Has narrow leathery leaves, yellowish flowers in clusters of 3, and sticky, round, white berries.



Mistletoe was the "golden" bough that saved the legendary Aeneas from the underworld.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to Europe and northern Asia, European mistletoe grows on host trees, especially apple trees (*Malus* species). It is harvested in autumn.

Parts Used Leaves, branches, berries.

Constituents Mistletoe contains glycoproteins, polypeptides (viscotoxins), lectins, flavonoids, caffeic and other acids, lignans, acetylcholine, and, in the berries, polysaccharides. Viscotoxins inhibit tumors and stimulate immune resistance.

History & Folklore In Norse mythology, a mistletoe bough was used to slay Balder, the god of peace. The plant was subsequently entrusted to the goddess of love, and kissing under it became obligatory.

Medicinal Actions & Uses European mistletoe is chiefly used to lower blood pressure and heart rate, ease anxiety, and promote sleep. In low doses it also relieves panic attacks and headaches, and improves the ability to concentrate. The plant is also prescribed for tinnitus and epilepsy. It may be used to treat hyperactivity in children. In anthroposophical medicine, extracts of the berries are injected to treat cancer.

Research European mistletoe's efficacy as an anticancer treatment has been subject to significant research. There is no doubt that certain constituents, especially the viscotoxins, exhibit an anticancer activity, but the value of the whole plant in cancer treatment is not yet fully accepted.

⚠ **Caution** European mistletoe, and especially the berries, is highly toxic. Take only under professional supervision.

Vitis vinifera (Vitaceae) Grape

Description Deciduous climber with erect stems, tendrils, palm-shaped leaves, clusters of small, pale green flowers, and bunches of fruit (grapes) that vary in color from green to black.

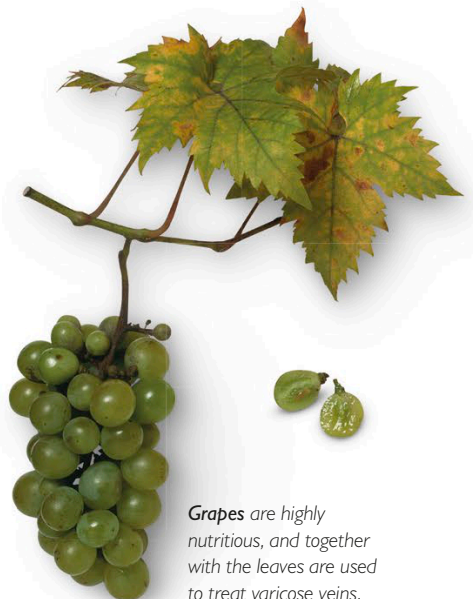
Habitat & Cultivation Native to southern Europe and western Asia, grapes are cultivated in warm temperate regions throughout the world for their fruit and to produce wine. The leaves are collected in summer; the fruit in autumn.

Parts Used Leaves, fruit, seeds, sap.

Constituents Grapes contain flavonoids, tannins, tartrates, inositol, carotenes, choline, and sugars. The fruit contains tartaric and malic acids, sugars, pectin, tannin, flavone glycosides, anthocyanins (in red leaves and red grapes), vitamins A, B₁, B₂, and C, and minerals. The anthocyanins reduce capillary permeability.

History & Folklore Nicholas Culpepper in 1652 extolled the virtues of the grape vine, describing it as "a most gallant tree of the sun very sympathetic to the body of man, and that's the reason spirit of wine is the greatest cordial amongst all vegetables."

Medicinal Actions & Uses Grape leaves, especially the red leaves, are astringent and anti-inflammatory. They are taken as an infusion to treat diarrhea, heavy menstrual bleeding, and uterine hemorrhage, as a wash for mouth ulcers, and as a douche for vaginal discharge. Red leaves and grapes are helpful in the treatment of varicose veins, hemorrhoids, and capillary fragility. The sap from the branches is used as an eyewash. Grapes are nourishing and mildly laxative and they support the body through illness, especially of the gastrointestinal tract and liver. Because the nutrient content of grapes is close to that of blood plasma, grape fasts are recommended for detoxification.



Grapes are highly nutritious, and together with the leaves are used to treat varicose veins.

The dried fruit (raisins or currants) is mildly expectorant and emollient, with a slight effect in easing coughs. Wine vinegar is astringent, cooling, and soothing to the skin.

Research Grape-seed extract has potent antioxidant and circulatory-protective activity. It appears to normalize blood pressure and heart rate, working best as a preventative, antiaging remedy that supports healthy circulation. One study found grape-seed extract reduced leg swelling in healthy women required to sit for long periods of time at work. Recent studies also indicate that grape-seed extract can be useful in nonalcoholic fatty liver disease and type 2 diabetes.

Ziziphus jujuba (Rhamnaceae) Jujube, Da Zao (Chinese)

Description Spiny deciduous tree growing to approximately 26 ft (8 m). Has oblong, bluntly toothed leaves, clusters of small greenish-yellow flowers, and reddish-brown or black oval fruit.

Habitat & Cultivation Native to China, Japan and Southeast Asia, the jujube is widely cultivated in tropical and subtropical regions of Asia and the Mediterranean. The fruit is collected in early autumn.

Part Used Fruit.

Constituents Jujube contains saponins, bioflavonoids, polyphenols, polysaccharides, volatile oil, mucilage, vitamins A, B₂, and C, in addition to calcium, phosphorus, and iron. It contains 20 times more vitamin C than citrus fruit.

History & Folklore Used in Chinese herbal medicine for at least 2,500 years, jujube has a pleasant, sweet taste and high nutritional value. It is mentioned in the *Classic of Odes*, a 6th-century BCE anthology of Chinese poetry.

Medicinal Actions & Uses Jujube is both a delicious fruit and an effective herbal remedy. It aids weight gain, improves muscular strength, and increases stamina. In Chinese medicine, jujube is prescribed as a *qi* tonic to strengthen liver function. Mildly sedative and antiallergenic, it is given to reduce irritability and restlessness. It is also used to improve the taste of unpalatable prescriptions.

Research In Japan, jujube has been shown to increase immune-system resistance. In China, laboratory animals fed a jujube decoction gained weight and showed improved endurance. In one clinical study, 12 patients with liver ailments were given jujube, peanuts, and brown sugar nightly. In 4 weeks, their liver function had improved.

Related Species The sedative *Z. spinosa* is used in Chinese medicine to "nourish the heart and quieten the spirit."